

MAHARASHTRA

QUITE A SHINDIG

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

A warning shot has been fired. Maharashtra deputy chief minister Eknath Shinde's comment about people who "took him lightly" suffering after the fact was no less than that. The reference was clear enough: the 2022 palace coup in the state, where he pulled the rug from under then-united Shiv Sena chief and CM Uddhav Thackeray. No one missed its dire resonance in the present context. Shinde's disgruntlement at being denied another shot at the CM's chair has been evident. He has skipped meetings chaired by the new man in the hot seat, the BJP's Devendra Fadnavis, and has also been holding parallel meetings to review the functioning of various departments.

Fadnavis, meanwhile, has rolled back many decisions taken during Shinde's chief ministerial tenure, and even ordered investigations into some of them. For instance, the Rs 900 crore Kharpudi housing project in Jalna district, approved in February 2023, faces a probe; as does the move to take 1,310 buses on rent for the Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC), reportedly at higher rates.

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE